Computing terms

bit

The smallest representation of computer storage. A bit can be either a 0 (off) or 1 (on). A bit represents the electrical state of a circuit on a motherboard (i.e. on or off).

See byte

Boolean function

Mathematical logic used for searching computer databases. Common Boolean functions include AND, OR and NOT.

Example

Database Search: first name = 'John' AND age = '20'

This will only return all people with the first name of John who are aged 20.

Database Search: first name = 'John' OR age = '20'

This will return all people with the first name of John and all people who are aged 20.

Database Search: first name = 'John' NOT age = '20'

This will return all people with the first name of John who are not 20 years old.

byte

A measurement of computer-based storage and also representation of computer data.

1 byte = 8 bits

Example

10011101 = 1 byte (computer-based storage)

10011101 = 157 (computer data)

See bit, kilobyte

CPU
(Central Processing Unit)

The central part of the computer which controls all of the processing of data. It is situated on the motherboard of a computer system and its speed is measured in hertz.

See hertz, kilohertz, megahertz, gigahertz

flowchart

A method of describing an algorithm using symbols.

Symbols used:

- Terminal – to begin and end the flowchart
- Process – an action or step
- Decision – alternate options or pathways
- Flowline – used to connect symbols together and to describe the path of the algorithm

See algorithm

gigabyte
(Gb)

A measurement of computer-based storage.

1 gigabyte = 1024 megabytes

See bit, byte, kilobyte, megabyte, terabyte

gigahertz (GHz)

One billion cycles or electrical pulses per second of a computer CPU.

1 GHz = 1000 MHz = 1 000 000 Kz = 1000 000 000 Hz

See CPU, hertz, kilohertz, megahertz